

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called 'The Seven Buddhas'

Ārya-sapta-buddha-kanā-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 270 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་བ་དྲུག་པ་ཞེས་བུ་བྱ་བ་ཞེས་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མཛན།

Toh 270 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in English as "The Seven Buddhas," in Sanskrit as the Ārya-sapta-buddha-ka-nā-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra, and in Tibetan as Pakpa Sangyé Dünpa Shéjawa Tekpa Chenpo'i Do. It belongs to the general class of sūtra literature and recounts a teaching delivered by the Buddha on the summit of Mount Kailāsa, in the company of a vast assembly of monks and advanced bodhisattvas including Maitreya, Ākāśagarbha, and Samantabhadra. As its title suggests, the text centers on the theme of the seven buddhas, situating this teaching within a rich cosmological and devotional context characteristic of Mahāyāna scripture.

In the language of India: Ārya-sapta-buddha-ka-nā-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called "The Seven Buddhas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling on the summit of Mount Tise (Kailāsa), in a divine abode, not far at all from where the sages practiced — together with a great Saṅgha of monks numbering around five hundred, and five hundred bodhisattvas, namely: the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya (Loving-Kindness); the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha (Essence of Space); Samantabhadra; Anantapuṣpa (Boundless Flowers); Sarvatrapuṣpa (Flowers Everywhere); and so forth — all of them bodhisattvas who were bound by only one more birth, assembled together in that same place.

Then the Blessed One, there in the forest grove on that very mountain summit, observed a monk who had been seized by a spirit and was writhing in agony, stripped bare without clothes, his arms outstretched, weeping.

Thereupon the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha, drew his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee upon the ground, and bowing with palms joined in the direction of the Blessed One, addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, who is this in the middle of the sky uttering the cry 'Kyi hud!' — and who is this monk, stripped bare, without garments, his one

hand empty?"

Then the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, this one has been struck by illness. And that other one has also been struck by illness."

Thereupon the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha, addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, may the Blessed One please teach and proclaim the knowledge-mantra (vidyā-mantra) that utterly pacifies all illness and repels all spirits."

Then the Blessed One performed a buddha-emanation, and from the sky appeared six Tathāgatas. The seventh is the Blessed One himself, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni. Then the Tathāgata Vipāśyin took his place in the sky above, and for the benefit of all sentient beings — to utterly pacify all illness and repel all spirits — proclaimed these bases of secret mantra:

Namo buddhāya. Namo dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Tadyathā: oṃ hulu hulu, hila hili ya, namo jaka, nama ścanāya, namo namaḥ svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Vipāśyin declared to the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, whoever carries this knowledge-mantra, or recites it, or causes it to be perfected — no weapon can harm that person's body; they will not meet their end from water, or from the suffering of sickness; they will not die an untimely death, nor will they meet a timely end by premature dying. Even if they consume poison, it will become like food. If this mantra is recited seven times over food and drink and then consumed, harm from enemies will not arise. They will not be struck by any illness. They will live long. They will retain what they hear. They will behold the forms of the seven Tathāgatas. If the mantra is recited into an ear pierced by a weapon and sesame-flower butter is applied therein — and for those struck by leprosy and dropsy, if butter blended with blue lotus, cardamom, and knotgrass plants is given — all illnesses will be healed. It may also be applied in all activities."

Then the Tathāgata Uṣṇīṣa (the Crowned One) dwelt in the sky above and, for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, and for the repelling of all spirits, declared these foundations of secret mantra:

Namo buddhāya. Namo dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Oṃ paca paca pācaya pācaya sarva bhūtānāṃ. Chindha kīlaya para vidyānāṃ svāhā.

Ākāśagarbha, these foundations of secret mantra were taught by many hundreds of thousands of ten million buddhas for the benefit of all sentient

beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, for the reversal of errors in meditation, for the reversal of all evil dreams, and for the prevention of untimely death. I too now set them forth. Ākāśagarbha, take up this essence I have now declared.

Whoever calls to mind this essence of mine three times a day — harm from enemies will not arise for that person. In dreams while lying asleep, they will behold the form of a Tathāgata. They will not die a violent death. When they pass from this life, they will encounter a Tathāgata and will bring joy to that Tathāgata.

Now, the other ritual procedures associated with this are as follows. For all illnesses, one should bind with thread. For those afflicted by fevers, one recites the mantra over fresh butter and administers it. One should bind the directions with water. One protects oneself with thread. For spirit afflictions of children, one applies a blue thread. Into an ear pierced by a weapon, one recites seven times. For others as well, one should apply this according to one's own understanding.

Then all the Tathāgatas, the Protectors of All, dwelt in the sky above and, for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, and for the repelling of all spirits, declared these foundations of secret mantra:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Oṃ kala kala. Kili kili. Kulu kulu. Kula udsādhanaṃ sādhanāṃ kuru. Sarva grahāṇāṃ svāhā.

Ākāśagarbha, these foundations of secret mantra were declared by all the Tathāgatas of the Good Eon — those of the past, those yet to come, and those of the present. I too now set them forth. Ākāśagarbha, you should take up these foundations of secret mantra.

Whoever holds them, reads them, or perfects them — weapons cannot harm that person's body, poison cannot harm them, plant-poison cannot harm them, epidemic illness will not strike them, and they will not die from drowning, from untimely death, or from violent death — with the sole exception of karmic obscurations from previous lives.

Whatever monk, nun, layman, or laywoman rises at dawn, washes their head, and recites this one hundred and eight times before a Tathāgata — all the karmic obscurations of that person will be purified. Whatever sentient beings harbor enmity toward them, and whatever kings — those will speak first. All sentient beings will come under that person's influence. One should call this to

mind in all situations of fear. For all conflicts, battles, disputes, and quarrels, one should apply a white thread. For eye disease, one makes a thread from a tree that bears milk-sap and ties it to the ear. One who wishes to rout an army should perform fire oblation one hundred and eight times with sesame rice that has been immersed in yogurt and honey. Rājānāṃ rāja mātraṃ vāva śīkaro tu kāmēna. One should perform fire oblation with fuel-sticks from a milk-sap tree, using a smoke-fire, and offer sesame one thousand times.

For one who wishes to purify all obscurations and transgressions of oneself and all sentient beings, and to accomplish great splendor and a great mass of wealth — one should perform fire oblation with fuel-sticks from a milk-sap tree, using a smoke-fire, and offer sesame one thousand times. For one who wishes to purify all transgressions whatsoever —

For one who wishes to accomplish all vidyā mantras and to bathe oneself: one should bathe using spikenard, nalada, cumin, śīrīṣa, bdellium resin, saffron, costus root, indravaruṇa, the wood of the Bodhi tree, and mango sprouts. One should fast for one day in the presence of a buddha image and set down a full, brimming vase. In the fifth month, before a buddha image, one should perform ablution with the mantra, reciting the heart dhāraṇī one hundred and eight times.

For one who wishes to render poison harmless: before a buddha image, one should recite the mantra one hundred and eight times, naming the individual by name, while using an acacia thorn to write in wet dung, and perform fire oblation — then the poison will be rendered harmless. If it is also applied to all activities of warding off spirits and the like, one will come to dwell at ease.

Then the Tathāgata, called Dispeller of Wrong Belief, residing in the sky above, spoke these dhāraṇī foundations for the benefit of all sentient beings, to thoroughly pacify all illness, and to repel all spirits:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Namaḥ Krakucchandāya tathāgatāya arhate samyaksambuddhāya. Oṃ kaṭa kaṭa, kaṭha kaṭha, kiṭi kiṭi, kiṭhi kiṭhi, kitāpaya namaḥ svāhā.

This heart dhāraṇī of Ākāśagarbha, the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened buddha, called Dispeller of Wrong Belief — proclaimed by as many as the grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā, rejoicing together — take up this heart dhāraṇī. If one takes it up, grasps it, and brings it to complete fulfillment, then in future times, when monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen of that era obtain faith in the Three Jewels, perform ablution, and make offerings

to the Blessed One with flowers, incense, and fragrances, and then recite this mantra one hundred and eight times, they will remember their past lives for seven lifetimes. Among the gods they will attain the very greatness of a god. Among humans they will become a wheel-turning king. Or, if one accomplishes this according to the prescribed rite, one will attain a final human birth. Passing from this life, one will be born in the world-realm of Sukhāvatī. And if one recites it constantly in this very life, one will be freed from all illness. One will retain what one hears. If one recites the mantra seven times over food and drink and then eats and drinks them, one will be freed from all illness. If one wishes to quench thirst, one should apply the ablution to all food using one hundred and eight recitations. If one is to make an incision in a vein, one should do it with a copper needle. If one wishes to be freed from all fighting, disputes, and bondage, one should recite seven times — and wealth will always increase, and one will be freed from all obstructors and misleading demons.

If one wishes to see a Tathāgata, one should draw a maṇḍala in a pure place on the ground around a stūpa, burn agaru incense, recite one hundred and eight times, and then, at that spot, with the head turned to face east, lie down to sleep — then one will see the Tathāgata. Whatever one aspires to in one's mind, all of it will be revealed. Life span, strength, and all victories and defeats will also be revealed.

Then the Tathāgata, residing in the sky above a golden platform, spoke these dhāraṇī foundations for the benefit of all sentient beings, to thoroughly pacify all illness, and to repel all spirits:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Namaḥ Kanakamunaye tathāgatāya arhate samyaksambuddhāya. Tadyathā: oṃ sara sara sara sara, siri siri siri siri, sīrāya, dhama dhama dhama dhama, dhuma dhuma dhuma dhuma, dhumāya. Namō namaḥ Kanakamunaye.

tathāgatāya arhate samyaksambuddhāya svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Kanakamuni spoke these words to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, whoever holds this dhāraṇī and constantly recites it will not encounter the danger of weapons, will not meet their end by fire, water, or falling off a cliff, and will be able to tolerate all poisons as though they were food. They will not die an untimely death, will not die a violent death, and will live long. Their prosperity will grow great. They will constantly be in the presence of the Tathāgata and will be blessed by the Tathāgata. If it

is recited three times at each of the three periods of the day, all karmic obscurations accumulated from past actions will be purified.

"If one wishes to free another from illness, one should offer a torma as lavishly as one is able, fumigate with incense of aloe wood, and perform ablutions for all the planets. For leprosy, swelling, and liver tumors, one should apply soft shuka leaves mixed with honey, then recite this one thousand and eight times before the Blessed One, the buddha, and anoint with the mixture — all forms of leprosy will be healed. On the fourth day, one should take a garland of blue lotus flowers, recite over it one thousand and eight times before the Blessed One, the buddha, then bind it around a person's head — the fourth-day fever will be healed. If this is recited into the ear of one struck by a weapon, that person will be freed from derangement. For those whose bodies are afflicted by decay, fumigate with flowers that have been offered to the buddha. By performing these and other such rites, one accomplishes all actions."

Then the Tathāgata Kāśyapa, dwelling in the sky above, spoke these dhāraṇī foundations for the benefit of all sentient beings, to thoroughly pacify all illness, and to repel all spirits:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Oṃ hara hara hara. Ha ha ha. Namaḥ Kāśyapāya tathāgatāya arhate samyaksambuddhāya. Siddhyantu mantrapadaiḥ svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Kāśyapa spoke these words to the great bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, this dhāraṇī was proclaimed by as many Blessed One buddhas as there are grains of sand in thirty-two Ganges rivers. Ākāśagarbha, you should take up this dhāraṇī and master it fully. Whoever holds it, reads it, masters it fully, and recites it three times each during the day and three times each during the night — in brief, they will see the Tathāgata in their dreams. All their karmic obscurations will be purified, with the exception of actions from the most distant past. It may also be applied to all other purposes.

"For leprosy and white-spot disease and the like, one should take flowers offered to the buddha, recite over them one thousand and eight times before the buddha, then read this text and wash with those flowers — the patient will recover. For headache, one should place flowers offered to the buddha before the buddha and recite one thousand and eight times before the buddha. It may also be applied to all purposes."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, dwelling in the sky above, spoke these vidyā mantras for the benefit of all sentient beings:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Tadyathā: ghume ghume mahāghume, tale tale mahātale, cale cale mahācale, dhure dhure mahādhure, tiri tiri mahātiri,

kili kili mahākili, curu curu mahācuru, mili mili mahāmili, tili tili mahātili, dhume dhume mahādhume, cale cale mahācale, khiri khiri mahākhiri, cili cili mahācili svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Śākyamuni addressed the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha (Essence of Space), with these words: "Ākāśagarbha, to cure headache, one should use a blade and the palm of the hand. To dispel clouds, one should use a twig of the kāravīra plant. To remove poison, one should use water. The other purposes should likewise be carried out. It should be applied through the ritual of bathing. All rites may be applied at all times."

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One fell silent. The great bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha rejoiced, and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

Translator's Notes

- The text of the mantra is transliterated from Sanskrit syllables embedded in the Tibetan and is left in transliteration as it appears; its precise Sanskrit reconstruction is uncertain given the phonetic rendering common in Tibetan canonical dhāraṇī transmission.

The epithet འཕགས་པའི་བུ་ (Vipaśyin) refers to the first of the Seven Buddhas of antiquity; the text places him as the Tathāgata who speaks from the sky, distinct from Śākyamuni who is the seventh. This doctrinal structure — six emanated Tathāgatas plus Śākyamuni — is the defining framework of the Seven Buddhas sūtra tradition.

The substance glossed as "sesame-flower butter" (འཕྲུལ་ཆུ་) likely refers to a medicinal preparation from the sesame plant; "knotgrass" is a tentative rendering of རྩ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་, an Ayurvedic plant that is difficult to identify with certainty from the Tibetan alone.

- The mantra syllables are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan phonetic rendering and are not normalized to standard Sanskrit orthography, which is conventional for dhāraṇī texts of this kind.

The phrase rendered "the Tathāgata Uṣṇīṣa" translates Tathāgata Uṣṇīṣadhara or similar — the Tibetan gtsug tor can literally mean "possessing a topknot or crown protuberance," which is the uṣṇīṣa, a characteristic mark of a buddha. The name here likely refers to Uṣṇīṣavijaya or a related buddha-figure; the precise identity is context-dependent.

The ritual instruction "bind the directions with water" is somewhat elliptical in the source; it likely refers to a ritual aspersion sealing the four directions, a common protective rite.

The Sanskrit phrase Rājānāṃ rāja mātraṃ vāva śīkaro tu kāmēna is embedded in the Tibetan as a mantra or ritual formula and is left untranslated in the body, as it functions as a

mantra-utterance rather than interpretable prose.

- The text identifies two Tathāgatas in sequence: the first is "Dispeller of Wrong Belief" (Tibetan: log par dad sel), here functioning as the name of a buddha or a dhāraṇī-buddha-epithet associated with Ākāśagarbha; the second is Kanakamuni, one of the seven past buddhas. The phrase rendered "Dispeller of Wrong Belief" could alternatively be parsed as a title meaning "Destroyer of Wrong Faith," but the rendering given follows the most natural Tibetan reading.

The term rendered "write in wet dung" follows the Tibetan literally; this may describe a ritual medium for inscribing characters, a practice known in dhāraṇī-ritual literature.

- The text moves between two distinct Tathāgatas: first Kanakamuni concludes his section (the svāhā at the opening closes the mantra from the preceding passage), then Kāśyapa speaks, and finally Śākyamuni speaks. The rendering reflects this sequence faithfully as given in the Tibetan.

The term rendered "blue lotus flowers" for sna ma'i me tog follows the standard identification of sna ma with the blue utpala lotus; this is a conventional ritual identification in this genre of dhāraṇī literature.

The phrase "karmic obscurations from the most distant past" renders sngon gyi las ma gtogs so, which more literally means "with the exception of actions from the past" — likely indicating prior actions whose maturation has already been fixed beyond reversal; this is a conventional qualification in merit-and-purification texts and is not rendered with uncertainty in the body.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage with "praised" — the Tibetan ends at the verb stem without a closing particle, indicating the passage continues beyond the excerpt provided here.

The term rendered "kāravīra" is a Sanskrit plant name (Nerium oleander or a related shrub) transliterated into Tibetan; it is kept in Sanskrit as it is a technical botanical term in this ritual context.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.